

Taste of pain (sweet version)

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Taste of pain (sweet version)

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Summary

When the bond between you and your soulmate solidifies, you start to taste what they're eating.

Jason hates his soulmate.

Tim worries for his soulmate.

Notes

I had this idea lying around and decided to finalize it in an effort to get my writing mojo back.

This is the nice version of the premise despite the title, I promise! Enjoy the adorable comedy <3

See the end of the work for [more notes](#)

When the bond between you and your soulmate solidifies, you start to taste what they're eating.

Usually, people use that to try to communicate somehow — telegraph who they are or at least which part of the world they're from by eating ethnic and local dishes. It helps to narrow down the possibilities, and folks tend to be rather keen on finding their “other half”.

But not Jason. First of all, he can't afford to plan what he's eating around anything other than what he can get ahold of. Secondly, Jason hates his soulmate.

It's a weird thing to do, but he seriously can't feel anything else. He doesn't tell anyone, of course, but he's pretty sure nobody would blame him anyway, if they knew what it was like. Because while he has to fight for every scrap he can find — just like everyone else in the Narrows — his soulmate is *well-fed*. And honestly, there's nothing worse than stomach pains from not having eaten in three days while you taste balanced meals, posh desserts, and hot cocoa on your tongue *all the time*. It's an insult to injury, that's what it is.

He can't even ignore it. It's there, in the back of his mouth, every day like clockwork. Fancy, warm, and tasty. It makes him think of the better days of his childhood, days long gone. Mom's food never was quite *this* flavorful, but it was better than the bruised fruit and squashed sandwiches he fishes out of the dumpsters these days. The taste of his soulmate's food is a painful reminder of things Jason has irreversibly lost.

Jason hates his soulmate for that. And he hates himself for hating them, because it's not their fault that his life sucks.

Tim worries for his soulmate.

He's only had a fast-food burger *once* in his life (he bought it with his allowance one day when he forgot his lunchbox at home; when his parents learned about it, they forbade him from ever eating such *undignified* food again) but he knows the taste very, *very* well. It's one of the most common things his soulmate eats, after all.

Used to, at least. One of his clearest childhood memories is the stark contrast of flavours in his mouth: between the restaurants his parents took him to and the cheap street food of his soulmate, between his freshly-steamed veggies from Mrs. Mac and the stale bread on the other side, between his dessert and their cruddy gas station candy. It was saddening, but it *was something*. Then the time between his soulmate's meals became longer and longer, and the quality of food got worse and worse... Till now, where he celebrates every time he even feels food from them.

He's been trying to figure out who they are for years — who wouldn't want to meet their *soulmate* as soon as possible? — but with this problem arising, his efforts double.

So far, he knows quite a lot, given his limited information. He is sure his soulmate lives in roughly the same timezone as him, and judging by the general flavour profile and their usual foods, they're probably in the USA. Separately, tater tots, Velveeta cheese, or sloppy joes could be eaten anywhere by anyone, but all of them in this frequency? Has to be an American. The rate of New York-style pizza to any other kind suggests they might very well be living in New Jersey, too, so on the off-chance he's right...

He's going to try to help them.

"Mother, may I have a minute of your time?"

Janet Drake doesn't even look up from her papers. She's most likely checking over the finances of the company, or planning the next overseas trip. Either way, she's busy, and Tim knows he shouldn't bother her while she's busy... But she's been in a good mood today and it might just be the best moment to strike.

"What is it, Timothy?" she says instead of dismissing him immediately, which proves Tim's hypothesis about her current disposition.

"There's a donation drive at-"

"I don't have the time to waste resources on beggars, Timothy."

He flinches slightly. It's not going well, but he presses on. "It seems to build good rapport-"

Janet pauses for a moment, her brow creasing slightly. "We're not Waynes, we don't need the applause of the public."

Tim holds back his instinct to swallow nervously, frantically looking for a different approach.

"Think of the tax write-offs, though," he offers, trying to sound nonchalant.

His mother puts her papers down and looks at him, and for a split second that feels terrifyingly long to him — he thinks he's going to get scolded.

"That's... remarkably, that's a very good argument," Janet says instead. "We *could* use some deductions. What is the drive you mentioned?"

His eyes glimmer with renewed hope. "A local soup kitchen-"

"No, no, that won't do," his mother shakes her head. "That's too small. Not nearly influential enough for our purposes. Look up some nationwide charities for me, will you, darling?"

He pushes down the disappointed sigh and puts on a polite smile.

"Of course, mother."

He might not have achieved what he wanted, but at least it's *something*, right?

Jason stares at the plate in bewildered silence.

“Is something the matter, Master Jason?” Alfred asks worriedly. It’s unusual for Jason to delay eating, even if it’s something unfamiliar.

Jason stabs the food before him with his fork again. The Alaskan king crab and truffle gnocchi doesn’t seem to mind. “That was this?” he says, more to himself than to the butler. “This was what they were eating? Fuck.”

“*Language.*”

“Sorry, no, but listen, Alfie- I know this taste.”

Alfred quirks a curious brow. “Oh?” He is more than entitled to his confusion; after all, the entire point of this exercise was to get Jason accustomed to the... *unusual* flavours of fancy foods before his first gala.

“Yeah, I- my soulmate's had this kinda thing before.” He looks up at the butler, confused for a moment. “Well, maybe not *this*, but- I mean, I’m pretty sure it’s the same thing? But maybe this stuff just so happens to taste the same as, I don’t know, rotten broccoli, because the other things this person eats are *weird*, like, instant ramen with chocolate levels of weird.”

The elderly man chuckles quietly and motions to the rest of the dishes in front of the boy. “There is an easy way to find out. I sincerely doubt there’s much of an overlap between chocolate noodles and luxe appetizers.”

Jason nods, eats one of the caviar snacks, pauses, then hastily takes a bite out of the glazed quail legs. With each dish he samples, his eyes go wider and wider. “I can’t believe they’ve been eating rich-people grub all this time. Like I *knew* it was good, but I didn’t think it was *this* fancy!”

Alfred doesn’t comment, just nods along as Jason slowly digests both the food and the realization.

“Bitch,” the teen finally whispers under his breath, and seeing the butler’s expression, immediately follows up with an apology. “Sorry, I just- ... it’s so unfair, you know? I bet my diet made ‘em nauseous. I used to eat literal *trash* when I was on the streets, and I haven’t exactly been fed well back at home, either. And then there’s this assho-... *jerk*, this jerk who’s been snacking on goddamn lobster or something. How the heck can I be the soulmate of someone like *that*?”

“Well, if it’s any consolation, Master Jason, I don’t think they’ll mind the difference in ancestry.”

Jason scoffs. “How can you know? Maybe they’re a stuck-up, posh jackass who only wants to eat crème brûlée.”

“They certainly have some posh guardians,” Alfred notes, “but I doubt they had much say over what they ate so far, much like you.”

Jason pauses, mulling over those words for a while. Soulmates are usually of similar age and it strikes him that regardless of class, kids usually don't decide what is served for dinner. Hating on someone just because of their birth would be very hypocritical of him.

Alfred seems to pick up on Jason's doubts and smiles softly. "It's your mate, young sir," he says gently. "I'd assume you two should get along swimmingly regardless of your origins."

The boy opens his mouth to reply with something witty and jaded, as always, but nothing comes to mind.

"Would you like me to look into it?" Alfred asks when Jason doesn't retort with sarcasm.

"Look into what?"

"Into these foods. The caviar is from a very specific vendor, so if you're positive you've tasted this exact flavour before, we might have a chance of finding your mate. Wouldn't that be lovely?"

Jason looks at him in silence for a moment, sighs, and smiles. "Yeah. It would."

The sudden change in his soulmate's diet — from very little food to regular, hearty meals — makes Tim extremely happy for two reasons. One is that his soulmate is getting *significantly* better nourishment. That's amazing on its own. But it *also* means that he can go back to trying to figure out who they are, now with more information.

And the information is as follows: there's a pattern. Tim knows a pattern when he sees one. Or, well, in this case when he *tastes* one. There's no mistaking it. It's not just *regular* meals. The lunch is *on the dot* every weekday, and repeats in 3 to 4 week cycles.

It's a school meal.

That makes it easy. Judging by the quality of food, it must be a *good* school. The meals on weekends are great, too, which means that — for some reason — Tim's soulmate's quality of life has improved *dramatically*.

There are only so many upper-class schools in the state of New Jersey, after all. Most of them publicly post their cafeteria menu, too.

"I'm worried about my soulmate," Jason blurts out. There's been a lull in the stakeout he's holding with Batman and it felt like a good enough opportunity to talk about what has been bothering him.

Bruce makes a grunt of acknowledgement, encouraging Jay to continue, so he does.

"I... haven't been paying attention to it before, because, well... either way, Alfie's been asking me questions about what food I've tasted from them in the past, and it made me

think... It used to be fancy shit like you eat, but it's been getting worse the past year or two. They eat less and it's like, frozen meals a lot of the time, and a lot of soda, too."

Batman stays silent, but it's the warm kind of silence. Jason sighs. "I'm worried that something bad happened in their life. That they're... going hungry, like I used to."

That makes Bruce turn his head toward Robin, finally. "Don't worry. We'll find them before it can happen," he says, and it's all the reassurance Jay needs.

"Can we go get chilli dogs after this? It's my comfort food. Maybe it'll help 'em feel better, too."

Batman just nods, and Jason grins in response.

Tim is convinced that he's dreaming. What's happening can't possibly be real. But then he loses his balance and falls flat on his ass; it *hurts*, so he has to reconcile with reality.

He looks back through the zoom in his camera to make sure he isn't simply imagining things, but no. That definitely is Robin sitting on a rooftop with Batman, eating a chilli dog from a local joint.

And Tim can taste *every. Single. Bite.*

He blinks slowly and swallows his saliva.

Well. That- ... that makes it easier. It also explains a lot. He knows the story (at least the one published in newspapers) of Jason Todd — Bruce Wayne's latest foster kid — and it would check out with his soulmate's diet through the years.

Huh. Well. Time to figure out how to drop that news on them, then? But it's... it's Jason Todd. It's *Robin*. And *Batman*. So far, Tim couldn't even bring himself to approach them to ask for an autograph. He's not sure he's brave enough to go and tell Jason he's his soulmate.

He'll have to find out.

Jason answers Alfred's call intrigued, but not *alarmed*. It's unusual that anyone would come to see him specifically (anyone that's not a journalist, that is, but those Alfie would chase away *politely* right off the bat).

The moment he steps into the foyer the short, black-haired boy standing in the doorway — who he pegs as Tim Drake, a distant neighbour — locks eyes with him and reaches into his pocket. He pulls out a single small, wrinkly pepper. Upon looking closer, Jason recognizes it to be a ghost pepper.

Tim brandishes the vegetable as if to show it off, which just confuses both Jay and Alfred even further, then *chomps the entire thing down in one bite*.

“Oh my,” Alfred says quietly in a worried tone as the boy chews diligently. Jason just starts laughing; he doesn’t know why an upper-class kid would do something like that, but *man*, he will enjoy seeing his pasty-white ass suffer from the heat.

Meanwhile, Tim’s face pales as the spice registers, then he turns a beautiful, deep shade of red and his eyes tear up. He takes a deep breath, starts coughing, and then shuts his mouth closed, desperately *struggling* to not pant like a dog in response to the pain.

Then Jason’s laugh is cut abruptly short as the heat hits him too.

“What’s going on, Alfie?” he whimpers, confused, sweat pearling on his forehead.

“I’d wager your soulmate ate something really spicy, Master Jason,” the butler says with a sigh.

“But I can handle spice!” He’s eaten hot peppers his entire life. It’s been the one spice his mom refused to give up, and chilli dogs with extra kick are his favourite. Why then, *why* is he suffering this badly?!

“It seems like your soulmate can’t. Let’s get you two some milk, shall we?”

He basically lunges towards the kitchen, trying not to claw his own tongue out on his way there. When the elder hands both boys a glass of milk each, Jason gulps the entire thing in one go.

Tim refuses, though. He tries to hand the glass back to the elder. “La-” he stutters out, “lactose in- intolerant.”

“It will help with the pain, young sir,” Alfred nudges the milk back towards him. “We’ll worry about your stomach later.”

Jason smacks his already empty glass down on the counter, looks at the full one in Tim’s hands, and grabs it. “I’m gonna drink it if you won’t!” he says and guzzles that one too.

Neither brings him any relief and much to his displeasure, he also starts tearing up.

“Why won’t it work?” he whines. “I drank enough!”

“But he hadn’t,” Alfred says, pointing to the other boy.

In Jason’s defence, it takes him this long to piece together what Alfred is getting at only because he’s in pain. He looks at Tim, eyes wide. The boy nods and offers him a crooked, pained smile.

“You sonnova-”

“*Master Jason.*”

Jay sneers. “Drink the darn milk!” he orders and pours another glass for — apparently? — his soulmate.

Tim shrinks in on himself a little under the pressure but obediently drinks, just in time for Bruce to walk into the kitchen with a puzzled expression.

“What’s the commotion?” he asks.

“Ah, just young love,” Alfred says with mirth in his voice.

It takes an hour, three more glasses of milk and two slices of bread to subdue the spice enough for Jason and Tim to be able to breathe normally. Jason spends the entire time cursing Tim out (*creatively*, so he doesn’t go bankrupt over the swear jar later).

“Why the heck did you do that?” Jason demands when they finally can talk again.

Tim takes a moment to answer.

“I- well... I figured you wouldn’t believe just my word. That you’d want proof.”

“Did you *have to* prove it with the spiciest pepper in the world?!”

The boy opens his mouth. Pauses, raises his finger. The question obviously caught him off-guard. “There’s... different kinds of hot peppers?” he finally asks sheepishly.

Everyone stays silent for a moment.

“Goddamn, you’re dumb,” Jason says before he can stop himself. Tim lowers his gaze, and his lip shakes slightly, and Jay realises that letting his anger get the better of him was a terrible idea. “But I guess you’re brave, too, so I think we’ll get along,” he adds quickly, gently pushing Tim’s shoulder to try to salvage the situation.

Tim looks up and smiles softly. “I promise not to do it again?” he offers.

“Yeah, we’re starting your Do Not Eat list,” Jason says, smiling back at him. For once he hasn’t fucked up beyond repair. “So far it includes hot peppers, chocolate noodles and whatever the heck you’ve been getting on pizza.”

End Notes

Big thanks to Jei and Jade for the beta-reading!

If you wanna say hi or talk with me, you can find me over on [Tumblr](#) :)

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- Questions
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